- This social engineering by the BJP was done without losing the support of the upper castes.
- Yet, the entry of so many OBC and SC representatives into the party's power structures in UP meant that they became numerically much more significant in the party and upper-caste representation in the party significantly reduced in electoral politics.
- Essentially, the BJP became far more representative of all castes in UP (barring Muslims) compared to its rivals. In the process, upper-caste dominance in the party was significantly reduced.
- Crucially, while the BJP initially increased OBC representation in the early 1990s with leaders like Kalyan Singh (a Lodh OBC and the party's first chief minister in UP), OBCs were not dominant in the party's structure, as they became after 2013. Caste representation in the BJP for those lower down the caste order earlier followed the Congress model, with a leader like Kalyan Singh becoming a totem figure for the caste to mobilise around. What is happening now is significantly different. Instead of totem-pole figures, a large number of people from these castes are being given positions within the party, from the booth-level upwards, i.e., being given space in the wider tent.
- The numbers clearly demonstrate that the idea of BJP being an upper-caste-dominated party can no longer be supported, at least in UP. There is a huge chasm between the changes in the BJP since 2013, how it reshaped its organisational DNA after 2013 and the scholarly understanding of it. This means a significant overhaul is needed of our understanding of the BJP, the subterranean forces that are driving its growth and the scholarly understanding of it, which has hitherto remained behind the curve in this regard.

More specifically, to give a bird's-eye view of the numbers, OBCs and SCs accounted for as many as 57.5 per cent of the BJP's UP Lok Sabha candidates in the 2019 general election, 52.8 per cent of its candidates in the 2017 assembly poll that it swept, 50 per cent of its office-bearers in the state in 2020, 48.1 per cent of Chief